

Comprehensive Analysis of ESG Disclosures and Sustainability Integration for Telkom SA SOC Limited (2014–2023)

The telecommunications sector in South Africa occupies a unique position at the intersection of critical national infrastructure, digital transformation, and socio-economic development. As the primary incumbent and a significantly state-influenced entity, Telkom SA SOC Limited (Telkom) provides a sophisticated lens through which to examine the evolution of Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) reporting in emerging markets. This report provides an exhaustive expert analysis of Telkom's disclosure journey from 2014 to 2023, scrutinizing the transition from traditional sustainability reporting to a fully integrated reporting model aligned with global best practices and local regulatory requirements.

Section 1: Corporate Identity and Strategic Context

The subject of this analysis is Telkom SA SOC Limited, identified by the stock ticker TKG on the Johannesburg Stock Exchange (JSE) and frequently referred to in international financial databases by the Reuters Instrument Code TKGJ.J.¹ Telkom is a major South African integrated communications and information technology (IT) services provider.² The company was incorporated in its current form in 1991, emerging from the South African Department of Post and Telecommunications, although its roots trace back to 1910.¹

Telkom is headquartered at 61 Oak Avenue, Highveld, Centurion, 0157, South Africa.⁴ As a Public Limited Company (SOC Ltd), it operates within the Communication Services sector and the Telecommunications Service Providers industry.² Its business model is structured around several key subsidiaries and divisions that define its operational footprint: Openserve, which manages the wholesale and network infrastructure; Telkom Consumer, focusing on retail mobile and fixed-line services; BCX (Business Connexion Group), providing B2B ICT solutions; and Gyro, which manages the group's extensive property, mast, and tower portfolio.¹

The company's identity is inextricably linked to the South African state, which maintains a 40.52% beneficial shareholding, supplemented by a 15.89% holding by the Government Employees Pension Fund.¹ This significant state interest informs the company's social and governance priorities, particularly regarding the implementation of Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment (B-BBEE) and the drive for universal digital access.⁹ The identification of Telkom SA SOC Limited is verified across primary exchange data from the JSE, company investor relations disclosures, and secondary financial databases such as Reuters, Bloomberg,

and PitchBook.¹

Section 2: ESG Report Timeline and Framework Adoption Analysis (2014–2023)

The decade between 2014 and 2023 witnessed a fundamental shift in how Telkom conceptualizes and communicates value. This period reflects the adoption of "integrated thinking," where ESG factors are no longer treated as peripheral "corporate social responsibility" activities but as core components of the company's "six capitals" (Financial, Productive, Intellectual, Human, Social and Relationship, and Natural capital).⁶

The Formative Years: 2014–2016

In 2014, Telkom released its fourth Integrated Report, signaling a clear departure from siloed financial and sustainability reporting.¹³ The 2014 reporting cycle was governed by the King III Code on Corporate Governance and utilized the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) G3.1 guidelines.¹⁴ This period was characterized by significant regulatory friction. The Competition Tribunal imposed a R449 million penalty on Telkom for abusing its dominance between 1999 and 2004, and the company entered a R200 million settlement agreement to resolve "margin squeeze" complaints from internet service providers.¹⁶ These governance failures in the early 2000s, revealed and settled during this reporting window, necessitated a profound restructuring of the company's transparency mechanisms and led to the functional separation of its retail and wholesale businesses.¹⁷

Environmentally, the 2014 reporting cycle saw Telkom engaging CA-Governance to provide independent verification of carbon emission data for the Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP).²⁰ The verifier applied standards exceeding ISO 14064-3 to provide "reasonable assurance" on Scope 1, 2, and 3 emissions, which totaled 739,976 *tCO₂e* for the 2013/14 period.²⁰ This early commitment to high-level climate assurance set a baseline for the company's subsequent environmental disclosures.

By 2015, the reporting boundary expanded to include newly acquired subsidiaries like BCX, and Ernst & Young (EY) was appointed to provide limited assurance on carbon emissions in accordance with the Greenhouse Gas Protocol.²⁰ However, 2016 proved to be a volatile year for disclosure quality. A massive restructuring resulted in the departure of over 5,000 employees, which, according to the 2016 Independent Assurance Report from Integrated Reporting & Assurance Services (IRAS), led to a "complete absence of skills and experience" in collecting sustainability data.²² Consequently, the 2016 sustainability data was limited to Telkom Ltd, excluding subsidiaries, and IRAS reported significant under-reporting and inconsistent applications of health and safety definitions.²²

Governance Maturation and King IV Adoption: 2017–2019

The 2017 reporting cycle marked the beginning of Telkom's transition to the King IV Report on Corporate Governance for South Africa.²⁴ The board began aligning its Ethics Handbook and committee terms of reference with the updated "apply and explain" principles.²⁴ This shift was aimed at moving governance from a box-ticking exercise to an outcome-based philosophy, focusing on ethical culture, good performance, effective control, and legitimacy.²⁵

In 2018, Telkom's Integrated Report was recognized for its adherence to the International Integrated Reporting Council's (IIRC) framework and the GRI Standards.¹² The company was included in the FTSE/JSE Responsible Investment Top 30 Index, reflecting a strong ESG rating relative to its JSE peers.¹² Assurance during this period was provided by IBIS ESG Assurance (IBIS), which conducted Type II moderate level assurance engagements focusing on inclusivity, materiality, responsiveness, and impact as defined by the AA1000 Principles Standard.²⁷

The 2019 period focused on the refinement of the materiality determination process.²⁸ Telkom's "combined assurance" model began to mature, integrating the internal audit function (Telkom Group Internal Audit) with external assurers and risk management activities.²⁷ Despite these improvements, IBIS noted that data inconsistencies remained a challenge, although they were typically corrected during the assurance process.²⁸ This phase demonstrated that while the governance *framework* was robust, the *data management systems* for non-financial KPIs were still catching up to the rigor applied to financial accounting.

Strategic ESG Realignment and Climate Advocacy: 2020–2023

The onset of the 2020s forced Telkom to address deep-seated social challenges and accelerating climate risks. In 2020, the company faced labor unrest as it sought to slash 3,000 jobs—roughly 20% of its workforce—to manage the transition from legacy copper to fiber and mobile infrastructure.³⁰ Unions such as SACU and CWU took the company to labor court, highlighting a material controversy regarding the "Social" aspect of Telkom's ESG profile, specifically the adequacy of consultations regarding retrenchment packages.³⁰

In response to increasing investor pressure and the global climate crisis, Telkom's Social and Ethics Committee (SEC) and Risk Committee developed a dedicated ESG Strategy in FY2021, which was approved by the board in FY2022.³² This strategy formalized the group's commitment to achieving carbon neutrality by 2035 and net-zero emissions by 2040.³² The 2021 Integrated Report was the first to reflect the formal adoption of the Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures (TCFD) recommendations, providing a structured view of how the board oversees climate risks and opportunities.³²

By 2023, Telkom had further refined its disclosures to align with the GRI Universal Standards and participated for the first time in the S&P Global Corporate Sustainability Assessment (CSA), scoring 34/100.⁹ The 2023 reporting cycle also introduced the "ESG Impact Council," a hybrid

operational model comprising ESG champions from each business unit to ensure accountability and the tracking of ESG commitments across the group’s diverse subsidiaries.³⁴

Section 3: In-Depth Review of ESG Performance Indicators

Environmental: Natural Capital and the Decarbonization Journey

Telkom's environmental impact is primarily driven by its energy consumption, given the high carbon intensity of the South African national power grid, which relies heavily on coal. Consequently, Scope 2 emissions—indirect emissions from purchased electricity—account for approximately 23% of the group's total carbon footprint.³⁶ In contrast, Scope 1 emissions, derived from fossil fuels consumed by the vehicle fleet and backup diesel generators, account for only 2%.³⁶

Environmental Metric	FY2022 Baseline	FY2024 Actual	FY2025 Actual	Strategic Target
Scope 1 & 2 Emissions (<i>tCO₂e</i>)	852,782	639,041	576,395	Carbon Neutral (Scope 1/2) by 2035
Scope 3 Emissions (<i>tCO₂e</i>)	1,764,216	1,724,460	1,713,336	Net-Zero by 2040
Renewable Energy (GJ)	< 1%	13,320	33,284	100% Renewable by 2035
Potable Water Consumption (kL)	997,617	777,722	774,991	50% Reduction by 2030

Waste to Landfill (Tonnes)	743	644	610	75% Reduction by 2030
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The data indicates a significant 32% reduction in Scope 1 and 2 emissions from the FY2022 baseline.³⁴ This progress is attributed to several technical and operational interventions:

- **Decoupling from Fossil Fuels:** Telkom has aggressively pursued renewable energy, notably through a 1 MW solar PV project at its Telkom Park campus, which generated 749,664 kWh of green energy in its first year of operation.³⁴
- **Infrastructure Optimization:** The decrease in Scope 1 emissions was partially driven by "diesel optimization" and the installation of lithium-ion batteries to provide backup power, reducing the run-time of diesel generators during South Africa's frequent loadshedding events.³⁴
- **Scope 3 Transparency:** In a major reporting milestone, Telkom submitted its net-zero targets for validation under the Science Based Targets initiative (SBTi) framework, which were approved in October 2024.³⁵ For the first time in FY2025, the group's Scope 3 emissions—which represent the vast majority of its total impact at over 1.7 million *tCO₂e*—were independently assured.³⁵

Social: Human, Social, and Relationship Capital

The "Social" dimension of Telkom's ESG profile is dominated by two primary themes: the digital divide and the transformation of the South African economy. As a majority-owned South African entity, Telkom is a critical enabler of the country's National Development Plan.

Digital and Economic Inclusion

Telkom's Shared Value Strategy aims to create quantifiable commercial and social returns. The group has set ambitious targets for connecting underserved communities and supporting Small, Medium, and Micro Enterprises (SMMEs). By FY2025, the group reported connecting 19.5 million customers to broadband and fixed wireless services, a 67% increase from its FY2022 baseline.³⁴ Furthermore, the group's fiber rollout in townships reached over 231,000 homes, reflecting a 94% increase in three years.³⁴

Workforce Diversity and Labor Dynamics

Gender diversity remains a core KPI for the group's human capital management. The percentage of women in leadership positions reached 35% in FY2025, meeting the group's target despite what the 2025 Sustainability Fast Track Report described as a "challenging recruitment environment".³⁴ However, the social narrative is tempered by the history of retrenchments. The 2016 restructuring and the 2020 job cuts underscore a material risk: the "S"

in ESG can be eroded by the "E" (efficiency) in operational strategy.²²

Governance: Accountability and Ethical Leadership

Telkom's governance is structured around the principles of King IV and is overseen by a board that has increasingly emphasized ESG competence. In FY2021, the company appointed a board member specifically for their ESG expertise in response to increased investor pressure.³²

The group's transparency is evaluated through several external indices and ratings:

- **MSCI ESG Rating:** Telkom was upgraded from BBB to A between 2023 and 2024, placing it among the leaders in the South African telecommunications sector for ESG risk management.¹⁰
- **S&P Global Corporate Sustainability Assessment:** The company's score improved from 34/100 in 2023 to 48/100 in 2025, indicating a steady maturing of its sustainability disclosure and performance tracking.¹⁰
- **Sustainalytics:** As of 2024, Telkom's ESG risk score was 26.8, categorized as "Medium Risk".³⁶ This is a slight deterioration from the 2023 score of 25.8, reflecting the ongoing complexities of managing a large-scale infrastructure transformation.¹⁰

Section 4: Material Controversies and Regulatory Milestones

The period under review includes several significant events that have impacted Telkom's reputation and financial position, which are critical for any holistic ESG assessment.

1. Historical Abuse of Dominance (2012–2014)

The Competition Tribunal's R449 million fine in 2012 and the R200 million settlement in 2013 remain the most significant governance and ethical failures in the company's recent history.¹⁶ These cases involved Telkom leveraging its upstream monopoly to disadvantage competitors in the Value-Added Network Service (VANS) market.¹⁶ The settlement package included a functional separation of the group's retail and wholesale divisions, a move that fundamentally reshaped the company's business model and led to the creation of Openserve.¹⁷

2. Labor Court Interventions (2020)

The planned retrenchment of 3,000 workers in early 2020 led to a significant legal standoff with the Communication Workers Union.³⁰ The Labor Court's decision to order a temporary stay on these job cuts highlighted gaps in the company's stakeholder engagement process.³¹ This event serves as a reminder that "Social" performance is not just about CSI spending but about the fair and ethical treatment of the internal workforce during periods of structural change.

3. Spectrum Auction Litigation (2021–2022)

Telkom launched a court application against the telecommunications regulator, ICASA, to halt the high-demand spectrum auction, arguing that the process favored larger "tier-one" operators (Vodacom and MTN) and would entrench an uneven playing field.⁴⁰ The litigation delayed the auction by a year, but an out-of-court settlement was reached in April 2022.⁴¹ As part of the settlement, Telkom withdrew its case, and ICASA committed to conducting an inquiry into the existence of a secondary market for spectrum and addressing imbalances in certain frequency bands.⁴⁰ This litigation illustrates how "Governance" and "Regulation" are material themes that directly impact "Productive Capital" by determining access to the essential radio frequencies required for 5G rollout.⁴⁰

Section 5: Credibility Assessment and Structured Reference Data

The findings in this report are based on a hierarchical assessment of source credibility, prioritizing audited regulatory filings and independent assurance reports.

#	Reference (APA 7th edition format)	Source Type	Credibility Score (0–10)	Justification for Score	Relevance to Query
1	Telkom SA SOC Ltd. (2024). <i>Integrated Report FY2024.</i>	Primary	10	Official regulatory filing; includes board-appro ved disclosures and combined assurance statements.	Primary source for strategy, performance, and boundary data.
2	IBIS ESG Assurance. (2022).	Primary	10	Independent, licensed provider	Verifies the accuracy of specific

	<i>Independent Third-Party Assurance Statement to Telkom SA SOC Limited.</i>			using AA1000AS standards; rigorous methodology.	non-financial KPIs.
3	JSE Limited. (2024). <i>Company Profile: TKG.</i>	Primary	10	Official exchange database; real-time verification of listing status and share capital.	Confirms company identification and ticker validity.
4	MSCI ESG Research LLC. (2024). <i>Telkom SA SOC Ltd ESG Ratings.</i>	Secondary	8	Globally recognized rating agency; standardized methodology but utilizes some estimated data.	Provides benchmarking for ESG risk management quality.
5	Competition Commission of South Africa. (2013). <i>Commission reaches settlement agreement with Telkom.</i>	Primary	9	Official government disclosure; authoritative account of legal findings and penalties.	Essential for historical controversy and governance analysis.

6	PitchBook Data, Inc. (2025). <i>Telkom Company Profile.</i>	Secondary	7	Comprehensive financial data aggregator; highly reliable for deal history and corporate structure.	Verifies subsidiary details and investment milestones.
7	Peoples Dispatch. (2020). <i>Unions take action against South African Telekom's retrenchment plan.</i>	Secondary	6	News outlet specializing in labor issues; provides non-corporate perspective but may have inherent bias.	Contextualizes labor disputes and union claims.
8	S&P Global. (2024). <i>Corporate Sustainability Assessment (CSA) - Telkom.</i>	Secondary	8	Independent ESG evaluation based on rigorous questionnaires and public data.	Tracks the maturation of ESG disclosures over time.
9	Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP). (2024). <i>Telkom Climate</i>	Primary	9	Direct disclosure to a global platform; includes verified emission	Provides granular data on environmental strategy and impact.

	Change Response.			figures.	
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Section 6: Synthesis of Insights and Causal Relationships

The evolution of Telkom’s ESG disclosures reveals a profound correlation between historical governance failures and the subsequent adoption of rigorous reporting frameworks. The 2012–2014 Competition Commission penalties did not merely result in a financial loss; they forced a "Governance-by-Structural-Design" outcome through the functional separation of wholesale and retail activities.¹⁷ This structural change became the foundation for Openserve, which now serves as the group's primary engine for value creation in the fiber market.⁶ This suggests a first-order relationship where **stronger regulatory oversight and penalties catalyzed a more sustainable and transparent business model.**

A second-order insight pertains to the relationship between "Human Capital" and "Disclosure Integrity." The 2016 IRAS assurance report explicitly linked the mass exodus of employees to a collapse in the company’s ability to report reliable sustainability data.²² This demonstrates that **ESG reporting is not just a technological or accounting function but is deeply dependent on institutional memory and human capital stability.** When Telkom lost its "sustainability champions" during restructuring, it effectively blinded its board to environmental and safety risks for that reporting period, necessitating the intervention of external assurers to rebuild the data pipeline.²²

Finally, the adoption of TCFD and SBTi targets reflects a third-order shift from **passive transparency to active strategic alignment.** By committing to a science-based decarbonization pathway, Telkom is not just reporting on the past; it is restructuring its future "Productive Capital" (infrastructure) to be resilient against the "Natural Capital" risks of climate change and energy insecurity in South Africa.³⁵ The transition from diesel-reliant backup systems to lithium-ion and solar at sites like Telkom Park represents a move to decouple the group’s operational continuity from a failing national energy grid, thereby simultaneously reducing Scope 1/2 emissions and improving business resilience.³⁴

Section 7: Transparency, Limitations, and Recommendations

Data Limitations and Knowledge Cutoff

This analysis is based on information available up to March 2026, incorporating audited reports

through the FY2024 financial year and preliminary disclosures for FY2025. Access to certain non-public or paywalled ESG ratings (such as full MSCI or Sustainalytics analyst reports) is limited to public summaries and summary scores. Furthermore, as Telkom Foundation reports are typically issued "one year in arrears," the most recent social impact data may not perfectly align with current-year financial reporting.⁶

Unverified Claims

- **Real-time Greenhouse Gas Reductions:** While the 32% reduction from the FY2022 baseline is reported and assured, the exact contribution of "site terminations" versus "active decarbonization" is not always granularly broken down in public summaries.³⁶
- **Supplier Compliance:** While Telkom reports that 75% of suppliers are compliant with the Supplier Code of Conduct, the depth of the audit process for these thousands of external entities remains unverified at the primary level in public integrated reports.⁴⁴

Expert Recommendations for Independent Verification

1. **JSE Disclosure Portal:** Users should monitor the Stock Exchange News Service (SENS) for immediate updates on board changes, material acquisitions, or regulatory settlements.
2. **Telkom Investor Relations Document Archive:** For historical comparison, the full archive of Integrated Reports from 2012 onwards provides the most complete record of the group's evolving materiality determination process.
3. **CDP Public Database:** For technical analysts, the full CDP questionnaire responses provide significantly more detail on emission factors, climate scenario analyses, and water stress assessments than the summarized sections in the Integrated Report.

The trajectory of Telkom SA SOC Limited from 2014 to 2023 indicates a company that has successfully integrated ESG into its core strategic pillars. While historical controversies and labor challenges remain a part of its profile, the maturation of its governance structures and its commitment to international science-based targets place it among the most transparent telecommunications entities in Africa. Analysts and investors should continue to weigh the group's "Value Unlock Strategy" against its ability to manage the sensitive transition of its human and natural capital in the volatile South African context.

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